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Public Health & Safety Advocates Condemn California Assembly Committee on Governmental Organization for Caving to Special Interests

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Dangerous 4 a.m. Bar Bill Advances in State Legislature

SAN RAFAEL, Calif., April 24, 2025 /PRNewswire-HISPANIC PR WIRE/ -- Decades of evidence show that late-night alcohol sales bring increases in alcohol-related crime, dangerous driving, and damage to neighborhoods. For this reason, Alcohol Justice and advocates throughout California condemn the rubber-stamping of AB 342, the 4 A.M. Bar Bill, by the California Assembly Committee on Governmental Organization (GO).

At the hearing on Wednesday, April 23, 2025, seven legislators took principled stands against AB 342, either voting no or refusing to vote entirely: Laurie Davies (R- Oceanside), Diane Dixon (R- Newport Beach), Jesse Gabriel (D- Encino), James Ramos (D- San Bernardino), Kate Sanchez (R- Rancho Santa Margarita), Tri Ta (R- Westminster), and Avelino Valencia (D- Anaheim). Assemblymember Tom Lackey (R- Palmdale) also testified against the bill, though he is no longer on the committee.

The remaining 15 discounted testimony from Alcohol Justice, the California Council on Alcohol Problems, the Health Officers Association of California, and others, and voted to send the bill through to the Appropriations Committee. The legislators voting yes on the bill were Blanco Rubio (D- West Covina), Chair of the GO Committee, David Alvarez (D- Chula Vista), Marc Berman (D- Palo Alto), Isaac Bryan (D- Culver City), Juan Carrillo (D- Palmdale), Mike Fong (D- Alhambra), Mike Gipson (D- Gardena), Alexandra Macedo (R- Visalia), Tina McKinnor (D- Inglewood), Stephanie Nguyen (D- Elk Grove), Blanca Pacheco (D- Downey), Michelle Rodriguez (D- Chino), José Luis Solache (D- Lakewood), Esmeralda Soria (D- Merced), and Greg Wallis (R- Rancho Mirage).

"They had the chance to stand up for their constituents, and they failed to rise to the occasion,"said Raul Verdugo, Advocacy Director for Alcohol Justice. "But this is not the end. As this bill makes its way through Sacramento, we will have to work hard to make sure legislators actually hear their constituents and understand the facts. All-night alcohol sales are toxic for our cities."

AB 342 is the latest in a series of legislative attempts, reaching back over 12 years, to extend last call times in California. Each has failed. Despite parliamentary agreements in the legislature that the same bill cannot be reintroduced immediately after failure, State Senator Scott Wiener (D- San Francisco) and Assemblymember Matt Haney (D- San Francisco) insist on returning to the same poison well year after year.

These types of bills are deeply unpopular, with cities like Miami Beach that already had extended last call times but then began waging years-long legal fights to restrict them in the face of increasing alcohol-related harms. These

risks are apparent to California voters as well-in a recent Patch.com poll, over 80% of respondents said they opposed pushing alcohol harm into the early morning. In just the past week, Assembly GO Committee members received over 4,000 messages from advocates across the state, expressing opposition to the bill. That may well be because alcohol-related harm has already skyrocketed in California, so much so that the legislature has brought forth another bill (SB 548) mandating the state produce a plan to reduce the toll.

That plan might start with ensuring last call times-which the U.S. Community Preventive Services Task Force has long associated with increased violence, dangerous driving, and emergency services use-remain uniform and where they are.

Until then, Alcohol Justice remains committed to ensuring evidence-based, life-saving alcohol policy prevails in California.

"This bill isn't law yet. It's a long way to the Governor's Desk, and we have the science on our side,"said Cruz Avila, executive director of Alcohol Justice. "We will keep speaking out, reaching out, and standing up for the communities in the crosshairs of this bill."

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